

Imagined Futures of Artificial Intelligence in UK Politics

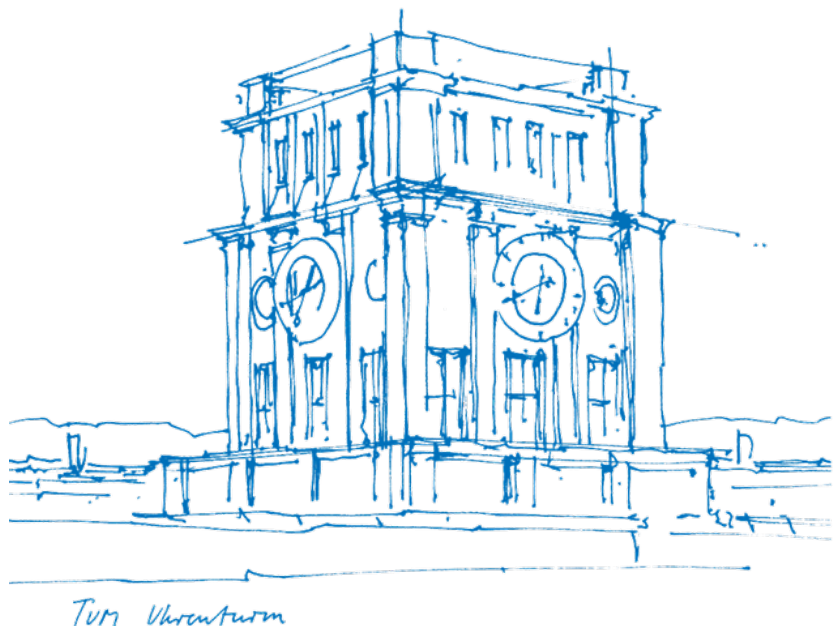
A Comparative Analysis of Parliamentary Debates and
Media Statements (2020–2026)

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1 Introduction and Context

Artificial intelligence has become one of the most prominent policy issues confronting the United Kingdom's political establishment. Since the publication of the House of Lords AI Select Committee report in 2018 (House of Lords Select Committee on Artificial Intelligence, 2018) and the subsequent National AI Strategy in 2021 (HM Government, 2021), successive UK governments have sought to position Britain as a global leader in AI development and governance. The trajectory of UK AI policy has been marked by a deliberate choice to avoid the comprehensive regulatory model adopted by the European Union's AI Act, instead favouring a sector-specific, "pro-innovation" framework that distributes regulatory responsibility across existing bodies such as the Information Commissioner's Office, the Competition and Markets Authority, and Ofcom.

This policy landscape underwent significant evolution between 2020 and 2026. The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the deployment of algorithmic decision-making in public services, from the controversial A-level grading algorithm of 2020 to NHS diagnostic tools. The government hosted the AI Safety Summit at Bletchley Park in November 2023, establishing the AI Safety Institute as the world's first state-backed body dedicated to frontier AI evaluation (HM Government, 2023). Following the 2024 general election, the incoming Labour government signalled continuity with the pro-innovation stance while introducing the AI Opportunities Action Plan in January 2025 (HM Government, 2025) and announcing plans for the Regulating AI for Growth Bill in 2026, which would grant existing regulators new statutory powers over AI systems. Alongside these developments, the creative industries mounted sustained opposition to AI's use of copyrighted material, and concerns over facial recognition, deepfakes, and online safety remained prominent in parliamentary discourse.

What is notable about these policy debates is the extent to which they are oriented toward the future. Because AI is an emerging technology characterised by deep uncertainty, policymakers cannot rely on conventional evidence to guide their decisions. Instead, they engage in what the sociological literature terms “futures-making”: the construction of narratives, expectations, and imagined scenarios that justify present-day policy choices, investment priorities, and regulatory architectures (Beckert, 2013). These imagined futures range from utopian visions of AI-powered economic growth and public service transformation to dystopian warnings about mass unemployment, surveillance, and existential risk.

This study investigates how UK political actors imagine the future of artificial intelligence, and how these imagined futures vary across political arenas and political groups. It poses two research questions. First, what imagined futures do UK elected officials and parliamentarians communicate concerning AI? Second, how do different political groups imagine the future of AI, and does the arena of communication—parliamentary debate versus public media statements—shape the types of futures articulated? To answer these questions, this study constructs and analyses two original datasets: 3,141 parliamentary utterances from Hansard and ParlaMint covering 2020–2026, and 270 media statements by elected officials and peers collected from major UK news outlets. The analysis employs topic modelling, sentiment analysis, and a custom imagined-futures frame classification to systematically compare AI discourse across arenas and parties.

2 Theoretical Framework

2.1 Imagined Futures and Fictional Expectations

The concept of “imagined futures” draws on a body of sociological and political science scholarship that examines how actors make decisions under conditions of fundamental uncertainty. The foundational formulation comes from Jens Beckert, whose work on

fictional expectations in the economy argues that capitalist dynamics are driven not by rational calculation of known probabilities, but by collectively held fictions about what the future will bring. Beckert defines fictional expectations as “pretended representations of future states of the world” that provide the cognitive anchoring necessary for present-day decision-making when the future is genuinely unknowable (Beckert, 2013, p. 222). These fictions are not falsehoods; rather, they are pragmatic constructions that allow actors to coordinate behaviour, justify investments, and build institutional arrangements oriented toward imagined outcomes.

Beckert’s framework was developed in the context of economic sociology, but its relevance to technology policy is direct. Artificial intelligence, as an emerging general-purpose technology, is characterised by precisely the kind of radical uncertainty that makes fictional expectations indispensable. No one—not policymakers, not developers, not the public—can reliably predict the trajectory of AI capabilities, their economic consequences, or their social effects. Policy decisions must therefore be anchored in imagined futures: narratives about what AI will do, what it might become, and what kind of society it will produce.

Suckert (2022) extends this framework by systematically reviewing how sociological scholarship has theorised the role of future orientations in social life. She identifies multiple overlapping conceptual traditions—expectations, aspirations, visions, scenarios, and imaginaries—and argues that they share a common structure: they are representations of possible or desirable future states that influence present action. Suckert emphasises that these future orientations are not merely individual cognitive phenomena but are socially constructed, contested, and politically consequential. In the policy arena, competing imagined futures serve as resources in struggles over regulation, funding, and institutional design.

2.2 Futures-Making in Policy

Thompson and Byrne (2022) advance the concept from abstract theorisation toward the practical knowledge involved in constructing futures. Their notion of “futures-making” highlights that imagining the future is not a passive exercise but an active, skilled practice that involves selecting, framing, and narrating particular visions while marginalising others. This is especially pertinent to parliamentary debate and media communication, where politicians must construct compelling accounts of the future to justify their policy positions, attract public support, and challenge opponents.

The relevance of narrative and framing to decision-making under deep uncertainty is further elaborated by Constantino and Weber (2021), who argue that when empirical evidence is insufficient to guide action—as in the case of both climate change and emerging technologies—narratives become the primary vehicle through which political agency is exercised. Narratives provide causal structure, emotional resonance, and moral direction that statistical projections cannot. In the context of AI policy, this means that the stories politicians tell about artificial intelligence—whether these are stories of national economic triumph, of workers displaced by automation, of children endangered online, or of a government wisely stewarding innovation—are not merely rhetorical decoration but constitute the substance of political decision-making.

Friedrich and Hendriks (2024) contribute a further refinement by examining imagined futures specifically in the context of sustainability transitions, arguing for attention to the diversity of future-making practices. They observe that dominant imagined futures tend to crowd out alternative visions, and that the plurality or narrowness of imagined futures in a given policy domain has consequences for the kinds of interventions that are considered legitimate. This insight is directly applicable to AI policy: if parliamentary discourse is dominated by economic-industrial futures of AI-driven growth, then alter-

native framings—around rights, equity, or precaution—may receive less attention and fewer resources.

2.3 Applying the Framework to AI Policy Discourse

This study operationalises the imagined futures framework through a classification of five frame categories derived from the theoretical literature and adapted to the empirical content of UK AI discourse. The *utopian-opportunity* frame captures narratives that envision AI as a source of economic growth, scientific advancement, and improved public services. The *dystopian-risk* frame encompasses warnings about job displacement, surveillance, existential threats, and the erosion of democratic norms. The *regulatory-governance* frame reflects futures oriented toward the design of institutional arrangements—standards, oversight bodies, legal frameworks—that will manage AI’s integration into society. The *economic-industrial* frame focuses specifically on commercial opportunity, investment, and competitiveness narratives. Finally, the *ethical-rights* frame foregrounds concerns about fairness, bias, transparency, and human rights in AI systems.

These five frames are not mutually exclusive, and a single political statement may invoke multiple futures simultaneously. However, the relative prevalence of each frame across political arenas and parties reveals the dominant imaginative orientations of UK AI discourse. By comparing parliamentary debates—where institutional norms, committee structures, and legislative procedures shape discourse—with media statements—where politicians communicate more freely to public audiences—this study can assess whether the arena of communication systematically shapes the kinds of futures that are articulated. The theoretical expectation, following Suckert (2022) and Thompson and Byrne (2022), is that futures-making is context-dependent: the same political actors may construct different imagined futures depending on whether they are addressing parliamentary colleagues or the general public through media outlets.

3 Methodology

3.1 Data Collection

Two datasets were constructed to enable comparative analysis across political arenas. Dataset 1 comprises parliamentary utterances related to artificial intelligence drawn from two sources: the ParlaMint 4.0 corpus (Erjavec et al., 2023), a standardised TEI-encoded collection of parliamentary proceedings covering 2015–2022, from which 1,013 AI-related records were extracted for the 2020–2022 period; and the Hansard digital archive, from which 2,224 speeches were collected for the period 2020–2026 using the Hansard JSON API filtered by AI-related debate titles. Combined, Dataset 1 contains 3,141 parliamentary utterances with speaker identification, party affiliation, and House membership metadata. The dataset includes contributions from both the House of Commons and the House of Lords, reflecting the significant role that appointed peers—particularly those with technical and legal expertise—play in AI scrutiny.

Dataset 2 comprises 270 media statements by elected officials and peers, collected from major UK news outlets including the BBC, Guardian, Telegraph, Independent, Sky News, Financial Times, and The Times, as well as official government press releases. Statements were gathered using automated web search queries combining politician names with AI-related keywords across the 2020–2026 period. The dataset covers 28 politicians spanning the Conservative Party, Labour Party, Liberal Democrats, Scottish National Party, and Crossbench peers. Full article text was retrieved and cleaned to remove web artefacts, navigation elements, and boilerplate content.

3.2 Analytical Methods

The analysis employed three complementary NLP techniques, all using open-source, non-proprietary tools to ensure methodological transparency and reproducibility—an approach consistent with recent methodological guidance on combining topic modelling

with qualitative policy research (Isoaho et al., 2021). Topic modelling was conducted using Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) via scikit-learn, configured with eight topics, 2,000 features, and bigram support. Custom stop word lists were developed to remove parliamentary procedural language and web scraping artefacts from the feature space. Sentiment analysis was performed using VADER (Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Reasoner) (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014), a rule-based model designed for social media and political text that assigns compound sentiment scores ranging from -1 (most negative) to $+1$ (most positive). VADER was selected for its transparency and computational efficiency; results were validated against DistilBERT, a pre-trained transformer model fine-tuned on the SST-2 sentiment benchmark, which produced broadly consistent patterns.

Finally, an imagined-futures frame classification was implemented using keyword-based pattern matching across the five theoretical categories described in Section 2.3. Each text was scored against curated keyword dictionaries for each frame, and assigned to the frame with the highest match score. Texts that matched no frame were labelled as unclassified. While this approach is less nuanced than supervised classification, it is transparent, reproducible, and grounded directly in the theoretical framework. All code and data are available for inspection.

4 Analysis and Comparative Findings

4.1 Topical Structure of UK AI Discourse

The LDA topic model identified eight substantive topics across the combined corpus of 3,411 texts. These topics reveal the thematic architecture of UK AI discourse and can be mapped onto the imagined-futures framework. Topic 5 (AI Regulation and Safety) and Topic 3 (Creative Industries and AI Economy) directly address futures-oriented concerns: the former encompasses debate about regulatory design, innovation policy, and

risk governance, while the latter captures the politically charged dispute over AI's impact on creative workers and copyright. Topic 0 (Online Safety and Children) and Topic 1 (Facial Recognition and Policing) represent domain-specific applications where AI futures are contested in terms of rights, surveillance, and public protection. Topic 2 (Data Protection and Public Services) reflects the integration of AI into healthcare, immigration, and public administration. Topics 4 (Legislation and EU Relations) and 6 (General Parliamentary Debate) capture procedural and contextual dimensions of the discourse, while Topic 7 (AI in Science and Business) reflects the commercially oriented framing that dominates media coverage.

The distribution of topics differs markedly between arenas. Parliamentary discourse is dominated by Topics 6 and 5—general debate and AI regulation—reflecting the deliberative and procedural character of parliamentary speech. Media coverage, by contrast, is overwhelmingly concentrated in Topic 7 (AI in Science and Business), with 238 of 270 media texts assigned to this topic. This concentration indicates that media reporting on politicians' AI statements is strongly filtered through an economic and commercial lens, regardless of the politician's original framing.

4.2 Imagined Futures by Arena

The imagined-futures frame classification reveals a striking divergence between the two arenas. In parliamentary debate, the distribution of frames is relatively balanced: utopian-opportunity leads with 24.5% of utterances, followed by regulatory-governance (19.6%), economic-industrial (18.5%), dystopian-risk (12.7%), and ethical-rights (5.2%), with 19.5% unclassified. This pluralism is consistent with the deliberative function of Parliament, where multiple perspectives are institutionally encouraged through committee scrutiny, opposition debate, and the Lords' tradition of cross-party expertise.

Media statements present a dramatically different picture. The economic-industrial frame dominates at 53.0%, followed by utopian-opportunity (20.7%), dystopian-risk (13.7%), regulatory-governance (10.0%), and ethical-rights (1.9%), with only 0.7% unclassified. The dominance of the economic-industrial frame in media is noteworthy: it suggests that when politicians communicate about AI through public channels—or when journalists select and frame politicians’ statements—the discourse is overwhelmingly channelled through narratives of investment, competitiveness, jobs, and economic growth. The regulatory and ethical dimensions that receive significant attention in Parliament are substantially marginalised in media discourse.

This arena-level divergence has implications for democratic deliberation. If the public primarily encounters AI discourse through media, the imagined futures available to citizens are narrower and more commercially oriented than those debated in Parliament. The regulatory-governance frame, which in Parliament accounts for nearly one in five utterances and encompasses critical questions about oversight, standards, and institutional design, drops to just 10% of media coverage. The ethical-rights frame nearly vanishes. Friedrich and Hendriks (2024)’s warning about the crowding out of alternative futures finds empirical support here: the media arena systematically narrows the diversity of imagined AI futures available to public audiences.

4.3 Sentiment Patterns

Sentiment analysis using VADER reveals differences in both the level and distribution of sentiment across arenas. Parliamentary discourse exhibits a mildly positive average sentiment of +0.094, with 30.1% of utterances classified as positive and 16.7% as negative. The remainder (53.2%) are neutral, reflecting the procedural and informational character of much parliamentary speech. Media statements show a higher average sentiment of +0.137, but with substantially greater polarisation: 53.3% are positive and 33.7% are negative, leaving only 13.0% neutral.

This polarisation pattern is consistent with the communicative incentives of the two arenas. Parliamentary speech, particularly in committee settings, tends toward measured and evidence-oriented language. Media communication, by contrast, rewards clarity, emotional engagement, and strong positioning. Politicians making public statements about AI are incentivised to articulate either enthusiastic endorsement or pointed criticism, producing the bimodal distribution observed in the data. The finding aligns with Constantino and Weber (2021)’s argument that narratives—rather than hedged assessments—are the primary vehicle of political agency under conditions of deep uncertainty.

4.4 Party-Level Analysis

The analysis reveals distinct imagined-futures profiles across political groups, reflecting the ideological orientations and institutional positions of each party. Labour, as the governing party from 2024, exhibits the highest positive sentiment (+0.151) among major parties and is most associated with the utopian-opportunity frame, particularly in parliamentary debate. This is consistent with the Starmer government’s AI Opportunities Action Plan and its rhetorical emphasis on AI as a vehicle for public service modernisation and economic growth. Labour’s parliamentary discourse foregrounds opportunity, while its media presence shifts toward economic-industrial framing—suggesting a deliberate communication strategy that emphasises commercial benefits when addressing public audiences.

The Conservative Party, which governed until 2024 and initiated the Bletchley Park summit and AI Safety Institute, shows a positive average sentiment of +0.121. In Parliament, Conservatives favour the regulatory-governance frame, reflecting their role in designing the UK’s “pro-innovation” regulatory architecture. In media, however, Conservatives shift decisively to the economic-industrial frame (sentiment rising from +0.092 in Parliament to +0.211 in media). This arena shift mirrors Labour’s pattern and suggests that

the economic-industrial imagined future is not a partisan construction but a media-driven phenomenon that affects both major parties.

The Liberal Democrats present the most distinctive profile among major parties. Their average sentiment is notably low (+0.014), and they are most strongly associated with the regulatory-governance frame. This reflects the Liberal Democrats' consistent parliamentary emphasis on data protection, civil liberties, and institutional oversight—a position aligned with their broader political identity as advocates for rights and regulatory scrutiny. Their near-zero sentiment score indicates balanced rather than enthusiastic discourse, characterised more by questioning and scrutiny than by advocacy.

The Scottish National Party is the only party to exhibit a negative average sentiment (−0.039). The SNP's AI discourse is evenly split between utopian-opportunity, economic-industrial, and dystopian-risk frames. In media, SNP sentiment drops further to −0.525, and the dominant frame shifts to dystopian-risk. This pattern may reflect the SNP's dual positioning as both a party of government in Scotland (with pro-technology ambitions) and an opposition party at Westminster (with incentives to critique UK government policy). The negative media sentiment specifically suggests that SNP politicians' most widely reported AI statements tend to be critical ones.

Crossbench peers, who participate exclusively in parliamentary debate and are often drawn from technical, legal, and academic backgrounds, show a near-neutral average sentiment (+0.018) and favour the regulatory-governance frame. Their media presence, though limited (15 texts), is notably negative (−0.373), suggesting that when crossbench expertise reaches public audiences, it tends to be through cautionary or critical interventions rather than enthusiastic endorsements.

4.5 Arena Shifts Within Parties

A particularly revealing pattern emerges when examining how the same party's discourse shifts between parliamentary and media arenas. For Labour, the dominant frame in Parliament is utopian-opportunity, reflecting the government's emphasis on AI as a transformative force for public services and national competitiveness. In media, however, Labour's dominant frame shifts to economic-industrial, and average sentiment drops from +0.157 to +0.096. This suggests that Labour's media communication de-emphasises the aspirational, public-service-oriented narrative in favour of commercially oriented messaging—potentially reflecting a strategic calculation that economic arguments resonate more effectively with media audiences and voters than abstract visions of public sector modernisation.

The Conservative shift is even more pronounced. In Parliament, Conservatives lead with regulatory-governance framing (sentiment +0.092), consistent with their authorship of the UK's regulatory architecture during the 2019–2024 government. In media, the dominant frame becomes economic-industrial and sentiment rises sharply to +0.211—the highest arena-specific sentiment for any major party. This pattern suggests that Conservative politicians use media appearances to project optimistic, business-friendly narratives about AI investment and economic growth, while reserving more measured regulatory discussion for parliamentary proceedings.

The SNP's arena shift is the most dramatic. Parliamentary sentiment is mildly positive (+0.100) with an economic-industrial frame, but media sentiment plunges to −0.525 with a dystopian-risk frame. This extreme divergence likely reflects the selection effects of media coverage: SNP politicians' critical interventions on AI—concerns about surveillance, job displacement in Scotland, or democratic accountability—attract more media attention than their constructive parliamentary contributions. It also illustrates

how media representation can distort the apparent ideological character of a party's AI discourse.

These within-party arena shifts provide strong evidence for the theoretical claim that futures-making is context-dependent. The same political actors construct meaningfully different imagined futures depending on whether they are operating within the institutional constraints of Parliament or the communicative demands of public media engagement. This is not simply a matter of tone or emphasis: the dominant frame category itself changes between arenas for every major party analysed. The finding has implications for researchers studying political discourse on emerging technologies: analyses that rely exclusively on either parliamentary or media data are likely to capture only a partial and potentially misleading picture of how political actors imagine technological futures.

5 Discussion and Conclusion

This study set out to investigate how UK political actors imagine the future of artificial intelligence and how these imagined futures vary across political arenas and parties. The findings offer several contributions to the understanding of futures-making in technology policy.

The first and most striking finding is the systematic divergence between parliamentary and media discourse. Parliament sustains a relatively pluralistic ecology of imagined futures, with substantial representation of utopian, regulatory, dystopian, economic, and ethical framings. Media discourse, by contrast, is dominated by economic-industrial narratives that foreground investment, competitiveness, and commercial opportunity. This divergence holds across parties: both Labour and Conservative politicians shift from regulatory and opportunity framings in Parliament to economic-industrial framings in media. The implication is that the media arena does not merely transmit parliamen-

tary discourse to public audiences but actively reshapes it, narrowing the range of imagined futures that citizens encounter. This finding resonates with Friedrich and Hendriks (2024)'s observation that dominant imagined futures can crowd out alternatives, and suggests that in the UK context, the economic-industrial imagined future of AI enjoys a structural advantage in public communication.

The second finding concerns party-level variation. The analysis confirms that different political groups construct systematically different imagined futures, in ways that align with their broader ideological commitments and institutional positions. Labour's utopian-opportunity orientation, the Conservatives' regulatory-governance focus in Parliament, the Liberal Democrats' rights-oriented scrutiny, and the SNP's critical-dystopian positioning each reflect distinct political projects and represent different answers to the question of what AI will mean for British society. This pluralism at the party level is a positive finding for democratic deliberation: it indicates that the political system generates a diversity of imagined futures, even if media representation compresses this diversity.

The sentiment analysis adds a further dimension. The finding that media discourse is more polarised than parliamentary discourse—with higher proportions of both positive and negative statements—supports the theoretical expectation that futures-making is context-dependent (Suckert, 2022; Thompson & Byrne, 2022). The practical knowledge of constructing imagined futures differs between the deliberative setting of Parliament and the communicative setting of media engagement. In Parliament, the institutional norms of evidence, courtesy, and procedure moderate sentiment. In media, the incentives of attention, simplification, and emotional resonance push discourse toward stronger evaluative positions.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. The keyword-based frame classification, while transparent and reproducible, lacks the contextual sensitivity of manual coding or supervised machine learning. The media dataset ($n = 270$) is substantially smaller than the parliamentary dataset ($n = 3,141$), reflecting both the greater volume of parliamentary proceedings and the challenges of systematic media data collection. The ParlaMint corpus extends only to mid-2022, meaning that the most recent parliamentary data comes exclusively from Hansard, introducing potential variation in text processing. Additionally, the inclusion of House of Lords members in both datasets—while justified by their substantive role in AI scrutiny—means that the parliamentary dataset is not limited to elected officials.

Despite these limitations, the study demonstrates the analytical value of applying the imagined-futures framework to computational text analysis of political discourse. By combining topic modelling, sentiment analysis, and frame classification with a theoretically grounded comparative design, it has been possible to identify systematic patterns in how UK politicians construct narratives about AI's future—patterns that would be difficult to detect through close reading of individual debates or media reports.

Future research could extend this approach in several directions. A longitudinal analysis tracking the evolution of imagined futures across key policy moments—the Bletchley Park summit, the 2024 election, the Regulating AI for Growth Bill—would capture the dynamic character of futures-making. Supervised classification models trained on manually labelled data could improve the precision of frame detection. Cross-national comparison with EU member states, where the regulatory imagined future has been codified in the AI Act, would illuminate how institutional context shapes the range of futures that political actors construct.

In conclusion, UK political discourse on artificial intelligence is fundamentally oriented toward the future, and the futures that politicians imagine are shaped by both partisan ideology and communicative context. Parliament sustains a diverse ecology of imagined futures. Media compresses this diversity into predominantly economic-industrial narratives. Understanding these dynamics is essential for anyone seeking to assess how democratic societies are navigating the deep uncertainties of artificial intelligence.

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